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INDIA’S RESPONSE TO THE CHINA THREAT SINCE 1949

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Indian security concerns about China date back to the early years of independence. At first, these centred on China’s forceful integration of Tibet and the consequences of Communist presence along practically the entire stretch of India’s northern border.[1] Three weeks before the People’s Republic was proclaimed on 1 October 1949, Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru highlighted the potential for communist subversion of, and encouragement of separatism in, India’s border areas.[2] More than a year earlier, in June 1948, K. M. Panikkar, the then-Ambassador to the Republic of China, emphasised the likelihood of Communist China denouncing the McMahon Line as the boundary between the two countries.[3] When China did that in the late 1950s, Indian apprehensions intensified. Sharing his concerns in this regard with Premier Zhou Enlai during their conversations in April 1960, Nehru noted that whereas the Himalayan border areas were a “distant”, peripheral region for China, “they are near, almost in some way the heart of the country” for India. Consequently, giving up the principle of drawing the border along the “high Himalayan ranges and high watershed” would be tantamount to placing the whole of